

GRADE 5 - UNIT 1: OUR NATURAL ENVIRONMENT

Core idea: The environment includes **natural features** (air, water, land, mountains, rivers and coral reefs) and **man-made features** (roads, houses, fields and gardens).

Sustainability means protecting, restoring and conserving resources so that future generations can also use them.

TOPIC 1 - PLANET EARTH

- Earth is the only known habitable planet. Air, water, land/soil, plants and animals support life. Seas and oceans make it appear blue from space.
- A **globe** is a model of Earth. Large land areas are **continents**; large sea areas are **oceans**.
- Seas and oceans cover about **70%** of Earth's surface.
- The seven continents are Asia, Africa, North America, South America, Europe, Australia and Antarctica. **Asia** is the largest continent.
- The five oceans are Pacific, Atlantic, Indian, Arctic and Southern. The **Pacific** is the largest.
- The Indian Ocean is bordered by Africa, Asia and Australia; the Atlantic lies between South America and Africa.
- **Latitude** lines run east-west and show position north or south. The **Equator (0 degrees)** is the longest latitude and divides Earth into Northern and Southern Hemispheres.
- Mauritius and Rodrigues are in the Southern Hemisphere. The tropics are 23.5 degrees North and 23.5 degrees South.
- **Tropic of Capricorn** passes through Madagascar and is close to Mauritius.
- **Tropic of Cancer** passes through North America, Africa and Asia.
- **Longitude** lines run north-south and show position east or west. The **Greenwich Meridian (0 degrees)** passes through London. Longitudes are numbered 0 to 180 degrees East and West.
- Important Indian Ocean waters: Mozambique Channel - Madagascar/Mozambique; Red Sea - Saudi Arabia/Sudan; Arabian Sea - Oman/India; Bay of Bengal - India/Myanmar.
- Natural sites to locate and protect: Great Barrier Reef - Australia; Amazonian Conservation Forest - South America; Victoria Falls - Africa; Grand Canyon - North America; Giant's Causeway - Europe.

TOPIC 2 - VOLCANOES IN OUR REGION

- Mauritius, Rodrigues and Réunion form the **Mascarene Islands** in the south-west Indian Ocean. They are volcanic islands formed by repeated eruptions on the ocean floor.
- Inside a volcano, hot molten rock is **magma**. It is stored in a magma chamber, rises through the **pipe**, leaves through the **crater** and flows down the slope as **lava**.
- Cooled lava becomes **basalt**. Accumulated ash and dust solidify into **tuff**. Molten lava thrown into the air may cool into **volcanic bombs**.
- Lava flows can form cones, mountains, plains and plateaus.
- An **active volcano** is erupting or may erupt at any time: Piton de la Fournaise (Réunion) and Karthala (Grande Comore).
- A **dormant volcano** is inactive now but may erupt again.
- Mauritian dormant volcanoes and heritage sites include Trou aux Cerfs, Bassin Blanc and Grand Bassin.
- Bassin Blanc and Grand Bassin are crater lakes.

Formation sequence: magma rises -> eruption -> lava flows -> lava cools -> basalt rock forms. Ash and dust accumulate -> solidify -> tuff forms.

TOPIC 3 - MAIN RELIEF FEATURES OF MAURITIUS

- **Relief** is the variation in the height of the land. Mauritius has three main relief features: mountains/mountain ranges, the Central Plateau and plains.
- A **mountain** is high with steep slopes; a **hill** is lower with gentler slopes; a **plateau** is high and fairly flat; a **plain** is low and flat.
- Mountain ranges are the oldest relief features - remnants of the large volcano that formed Mauritius. Erosion weakened the ring and rivers carved valleys and gorges. Main ranges include Port Louis-Moka, Black River, Savanne and Grand Port.
- **Piton de la Petite Rivière Noire (828 m)** is the highest mountain in Mauritius. Le Morne Mountain is in the south-west. Our mountains protect endemic fauna and flora and form part of our natural heritage.
- The **Central Plateau** was formed by lava. It is mostly flat or undulating, receives much rainfall and is the source of many rivers.
- Grand Bassin and Plaine Champagne in the south-west are over 600 m high.
- Plains lie mostly outside the mountain ring and near the coast. Main examples: Northern Plain (north), Plaine des Roches (north-east), Flacq Plain (east), Grand Port Plain (south-east) and Plaine St Pierre (west). Fertile plains are intensively cultivated, mainly with sugarcane.
- A **contour line** joins places having the same height above sea level.

TOPIC 4 - MAIN RELIEF FEATURES OF RODRIGUES

- Rodrigues has three main relief areas: the **Central Ridge**, sloping lands/river valleys, and plains.
- The Central Ridge is an east-west highland with undulating and hilly land. La Ferme and La Fouché Corail are undulating. **Mont Limon (398 m)** is the highest mount; Mont Malartic is 392 m.
- Explosive eruptions produced ash and dust which solidified into **tuffs**. Tuffs occur at La Ferme, La Fouché Corail and on the slopes of Petit Brûlé, Roseaux and Mangles.
- Land slopes from the ridge towards the coast. Rivers eroded the soft tuffs and formed deep valleys. They carried **alluvium**, which was deposited along river banks and near river mouths.
- Alluvial land is flat, fertile and intensively cultivated. Deposits occur near River Mourouk, Rivière Cocos, Rivière Banane and Baie aux Huîtres.
- **Plaine Corail**, in the south-west, is a low, flat coastal plain made of **limestone** - white rock formed from solidified wind-blown sand. Caverne Patate and the limestone quarries are heritage sites.

TOPIC 5 - ENVIRONMENTAL PROBLEMS AND PROTECTION

- **Beach erosion** is the removal of sand and other coastal material.
- Natural causes: strong waves, currents and storms. Human causes: past sand mining, jetties/buildings, pollution and damage to coral reefs.
- Effects: beaches become narrow; filaos may be uprooted; roads/buildings may be damaged; corals and other marine life are affected. Coral reefs reduce the force of waves and protect beaches.
- Protection: sand mining in lagoons has been banned; laws protect beaches; beaches are cleaned/restored; reefs and mangroves should be protected.
- **Soil erosion** is the removal of fertile topsoil by heavy rain or wind. In Rodrigues it is worsened by steep slopes, deforestation, overgrazing and planting crops on steep land.
- Plants bind the soil. Loss of topsoil reduces soil fertility and crop production. Planting trees and building **terraces** help slow water and reduce erosion.
- Nature reserves protect endemic fauna and flora, restore habitats and prevent extinction.
- Mauritius: Black River National Park, Ile aux Aigrettes, Vallée de Ferney and Blue Bay Marine Park.
- Rodrigues: Grande Montagne, Anse Quitor-François Leguat Giant Tortoise Reserve and Ile Cocos.

GRADE 5 - UNIT 2: DISCOVERY OF MAURITIUS & RODRIGUES

Arabs and Asian traders travelled in the Indian Ocean before Europeans. The Portuguese were the first Europeans to reach the region, followed by the Dutch. Their visits led to the naming of the islands and major changes in their fauna and flora.

TOPIC 1 - THE INDIAN OCEAN IN THE PAST

- Long ago, Arabs, Chinese, Indians and Indonesians crossed the Indian Ocean for trade. Old map names include **Persia (Iran)**, **Burma (Myanmar)** and the **East Indies** (mainly present-day Indonesia and nearby islands).
- About 500 years ago, European explorers sailed to India and the East Indies in large sailing ships. They wanted spices such as **pepper, cloves, cinnamon and nutmeg**.
- The **Portuguese** were the first European sailors to reach the Indian Ocean. They came from Portugal. The Dutch came from Holland; Arabs from Arabia; Chinese from China; Indonesians from the East Indies.
- The Portuguese route went from Portugal through the Atlantic Ocean, around Africa and the **Cape of Good Hope (South Africa)**, then across the Indian Ocean to India and the East Indies (Indonesia).
- Spices were valuable because they added flavour, helped preserve food and were also used in medicines and perfumes.

TOPIC 2 - UNDERSTANDING CENTURIES AND TIMELINES

- A **century** is a period of 100 years. Years 1-100 form the 1st century; 101-200 form the 2nd; 1401-1500 form the 15th.
- We are currently in the 21st century.
- A **timeline** arranges events in date order. It shows when events happened and how much time passed between them. Timelines may be horizontal or vertical.
- Explorer dates:
Christopher Columbus reached the Americas in 1492.
Vasco da Gama reached India in 1498.
Ferdinand Magellan reached the Strait in 1520. This passage connects the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean. It was later named the Strait of Magellan after him.
Francis Drake completed an around-the-world voyage in 1580.
- Van Warwick and the Dutch landed in Mauritius in 1598.

TOPIC 3 - THE MASCARENE ISLANDS

- Mauritius, Rodrigues and Réunion are the **Mascarene Islands**. They were named after the Portuguese sailor **Pedro Mascarenhas**.
- Portuguese sailors crossed the Indian Ocean for the spice trade. **Rodrigues** was named after the Portuguese sailor **Diogo Rodriguez**.
- Agaléga and Diego Garcia also received Portuguese names.
- The Portuguese stopped at Mauritius to repair ships and obtain food and fresh water. They introduced pigs, monkeys, goats and citrus plants, but they did not settle permanently.
- The **Dutch** were people from Holland. Like the Portuguese, they sailed to the East Indies for spices and made regular voyages through the Indian Ocean.
- In **1598**, Van Warwick travelled with eight Dutch ships. A storm near Madagascar separated three ships. The other five were damaged and were pushed towards Mauritius.

TOPIC 3 - THE MASCARENE ISLANDS (CONTINUED)

- The Dutch landed at **Ferney** in 1598. They rested, repaired their ships and collected food and water.
- A monument (Dutch Landing Monument) at Ferney, in Grand Port District, remembers their landing.
- They found thick forests, ebony trees, mountains, valleys and waterfalls.
- Animals included bats, parrots, dodos and tortoises; rivers and lagoons contained plenty of fish.
- The Dutch named the island **Mauritius** after Maurice Van Nassau.
- Mauritius was called the **Island of the Dodos** because the dodo lived only there.
- Mauritius became a useful **stop-over** for Dutch sailors because it offered food, fresh water, rest, a good climate and freedom from serious diseases.
- **Fauna** means the animals of a place; **flora** means its plants.
- Human arrival changed both through hunting, tree cutting and the introduction of animals and plants.
- The **dodo** was a heavy, flightless bird found only in Mauritius. Sailors easily caught and killed it for food.
- The **Red Rail** was also flightless. Both birds became **extinct**, meaning they no longer exist.
- Pieter Both was a Dutch Governor of the East Indies. He died with other sailors in a shipwreck caused by a cyclone near Mauritius.
- Pieter Both Mountain was named after him.

TOPIC 4 - RODRIGUES ISLAND

- Rodrigues is the **smallest Mascarene Island**. Arab explorers and traders visited it before the Europeans. At that time, nobody lived there and it was covered with forests.
- The Portuguese visited after the Arabs and named the island after Diogo Rodriguez. They used it for food, fresh water and ship repairs but did not remain there.
- The first Dutch sailor to land in Rodrigues was **Wolphart Harmensen**. He found food and water in the north, stayed briefly and then sailed to Mauritius.
- The northern place visited by Harmensen became **Port Mathurin**, now the capital of Rodrigues. A street there bears his name.
- Rodrigues once had forests with palm and latanier trees. Giant tortoises were abundant, but sailors loaded them onto ships for fresh meat.
- Birds found only in Rodrigues included the **Solitaire**, Rodrigues Warbler and Rodrigues Fody.
- The Solitaire became extinct; the Warbler and Fody still exist but their numbers decreased.
- Rodrigues' flora changed because people cut down many trees and plants. This shows how human activities can damage island environments.

GRADE 5 HISTORY & GEOGRAPHY - UNIT 3

Unit focus: How the Dutch, French and British settled the islands, their activities, and the reasons for major changes in rule.

1. The Dutch settlement in Mauritius

- **Settlement:** a place where people live. A settlement may be a village, town or city and usually has houses, shops or markets, schools and health services.
- **Why the Dutch settled (1638):** Mauritius was a useful stop-over for food, fresh water and rest on voyages to and from the East Indies. They also feared that the British or French might occupy it.
- **First settlement:** Vieux Grand Port. The area offered a sheltered bay and coves, rivers and springs, flat land, forests, animals and seafood.
- **Buildings and routes:** They built Fort Frederik Hendrik, placed cannons near it, made roads, built wooden huts and cultivated the land.
- **Food and farming:** They grew maize, sweet potatoes, peas, beans, vegetables, tobacco, grapes, oranges, bananas and lemons. They introduced sugar cane and deer from Java and reared cattle, goats and pigs.
- **Other food:** They fished and hunted bats, tortoises and birds such as the dodo, pigeons, parrots and wild ducks.
- **Main economic activity:** cutting ebony trees for export to Holland. Enslaved people were brought to cut the trees and load the logs.
- **Why the settlement failed:** cyclones destroyed houses and crops; rats damaged crops; maroon slaves attacked settlers; some settlers were not hard-working; the price of ebony fell; there were few people; and animals were overhunted. The Dutch abandoned Mauritius in 1710.
- **Rodrigues:** In 1691 Francois Leguat and his friends settled at the mouth of Grande Riviere near Port Mathurin. They built latanier-palm huts, gardened, fished, hunted and kept a diary about plants and animals, including the Solitaire.
- They left in 1693 because no ships brought goods and no more settlers came.

2. The French in Ile de France

- **After 1710:** sailors and pirates used the island. Pirates based in Madagascar hid in its bays and attacked ships carrying valuable goods.
- **French possession (1715):** France took Mauritius to protect Indian Ocean trade, defend ships from pirates and enemies, and use a safer stop-over. The island was renamed Ile de France.
- **Early settlement (1722):** Governor Denis de Nyon arrived with settlers and enslaved people and began a settlement at Grand Port. Land near rivers was cleared for houses and food crops.
- **Growing population:** officers, farmers, skilled workers and enslaved people came from France, Africa, Madagascar, Mozambique and India. Farmers grew food, reared animals and kept poultry. Fish and turtles came from Rodrigues, cereals from Reunion, and cattle and rice from Madagascar.
- **Mahe de Labourdonnais (governor from 1735):** introduced manioc, encouraged coffee, indigo and cotton, developed sugar cane, and built sugar mills at Villebague and Ferney. His residence, Mon Plaisir, had a vegetable garden.
- **Pierre Poivre:** created the **Botanical Garden of Pamplemousses** and introduced fruits, medicinal plants and valuable spices such as cloves and nutmeg. Seeds and seedlings were distributed to settlers.
- **Transport:** people walked or used horses, ox carts and palanquins; goods moved by mules, ox carts and coastal boats. Governor Souillac built a small port at the mouth of River Savanne.
- **Charles Decaen:** the last French governor, made new laws, founded the Lycee Colonial (later Royal College Port Louis), and developed Mahebourg with roads, drains and soldiers' barracks.

3. The conquest of Ile de France

- **Mascarenes in the 18th century:** the three islands belonged to France. Rodrigues had mainly fishermen, a few farmers and enslaved people. Philibert Marragon, the French officer in charge, had a farm called l'Orangerie near Baie aux Huitres.
- **Corsairs:** French sailors officially permitted to attack enemy ships during war.
- **Robert Surcouf, the 'King of Corsairs'**, sailed from Port Louis in small, swift boats and captured British ships and goods.
- **British aim:** to stop corsair attacks and trade safely in the Indian Ocean.
- **Rodrigues (August 1809):** the British captured the poorly defended island, built Fort Duncan and used Rodrigues as a military base.
- **Reunion (July 1810):** the British captured Reunion, leaving Ile de France as the remaining French island.
- **Battle of Grand Port (August 1810):** the British captured Ile de la Passe and entered the bay, but their warships became trapped in shallow sandy areas. The French won. Captains Duperre and Willoughby were treated at Robillard's residence, now the National History Museum in Mahebourg.
- **Final conquest:** the British prepared again in Rodrigues and landed at Cap Malheureux in November 1810 with more warships, weapons, British soldiers and Indian soldiers. They marched towards Port Louis. Governor Decaen, with fewer men and weapons, surrendered in December 1810.
- **Result:** French rule ended; Britain took possession of Ile de France and renamed it Mauritius.

4. Mauritius as a British colony

- **Empire:** a group of countries ruled by one powerful country.
- **Colony:** a country governed by another country.
- **British rule:** Mauritius became part of the British Empire. Its dependencies were Rodrigues, St Brandon, Agalega, Tromelin, the Chagos Archipelago and the Seychelles; they were governed by the Governor of Mauritius.
- **Sir Robert Farquhar:** the first British governor. French inhabitants kept their land, buildings, religion, language, customs and enslaved people, so few immediate changes occurred.
- **Agriculture:** Farquhar encouraged sugar cane because it resisted cyclones better than many other crops.
- **Roads:** he improved paths and built roads, including the main routes from Port Louis to Mahebourg and Souillac, making travel and transport of goods easier.
- **Agalega and Chagos:** people fished and worked on coconut plantations. Coconuts were sent to Mauritius for oil and soap, while some islands also exported guano for fertiliser.

Essential timeline:

1638 Dutch settlement.

1691 Leguat in Rodrigues; 1693 Leguat leaves.

1710 Dutch leave Mauritius.

1715 French possession.

1722 de Nyon settles at Grand Port.

1735 Labourdonnais becomes governor.

1809 Rodrigues captured, 1810 Reunion and Ile de France captured.

Main comparison:

The Dutch settlement remained small and failed.

The French brought more people and developed agriculture, transport, government and trade.

The British kept much of the existing way of life but expanded sugar cultivation and roads.

GRADE 5 HISTORY & GEOGRAPHY - UNIT 4

Unit focus: Temperature and rainfall in Mauritius and Rodrigues, map skills, rainfall formation, and climate change.

1. Temperature

- **Temperature:** how hot or cold the air is. It is measured with a thermometer in degrees Celsius (deg C). Minimum temperature is the lowest recorded; maximum temperature is the highest.
- **Daily change:** temperature is normally lower at night and early morning and higher during the day because the Sun heats the ground and air.
- **World pattern:** places near the Equator are generally hottest; temperatures decrease towards the North and South Poles. Mauritius and Rodrigues lie near the Tropic of Capricorn and have a tropical climate.
- **Weather stations:** temperature and rainfall are recorded daily. Mauritius sends readings to the Meteorological Station at Vacoas; Rodrigues has a station at Pointe Canon near Port Mathurin.
- **Isotherm:** a line on a map joining places with the same temperature. Isotherm maps help compare the temperature of different areas.
- **Altitude:** temperature decreases as height above sea level increases. Therefore, low coastal places such as Port Louis are warmer than high places such as Curepipe or Mare aux Vacoas. Even near the Equator, very high mountain summits may have snow.

2. Climate and temperature graphs

- **Climate:** the usual weather conditions of a place observed over a long period.
- **Seasons:** Mauritius has two main seasons: a warmer summer and a cooler winter. December, January and February are summer months; June, July and August are winter months. Many countries far from the tropics have summer, autumn, winter and spring.
- **Temperature graph:** a line graph showing the average temperature of a place for each month. Read the place and axes first, then identify the hottest/coolest months and compare locations.

Core rule: The higher the place, the lower its temperature.

3. How rain forms

- **Water cycle:** water evaporates from seas and oceans; water vapour rises, cools and condenses into tiny droplets; droplets form clouds and join until they become heavy enough to fall as rain; water then flows back through rivers to the sea.
- **Condition for rain:** air containing water vapour must rise, cool and condense.

4. Types of rainfall

- **Convictional rain:** common in summer. The Sun heats the ground; warm air rises, cools and condenses. Thick dark clouds form by early afternoon. Rain is usually heavy but short, often lasting one or two hours, and may bring thunder and lightning.
- **Relief rain:** South East Trade Winds are forced to rise over high land. Rising air cools and condenses, producing rain on the windward side. Relief rain is often lighter, lasts longer and may occur at any time, especially in winter.
- **Windward side:** the side facing the prevailing winds where air rises and more rain falls.
- **Leeward side:** the sheltered side where air descends, so fewer clouds form and less rain falls.
- **Prevailing winds:** winds that blow almost throughout the year; in Mauritius these are the South East Trade Winds.

5. Cyclonic rain

- **Tropical cyclones:** form over warm ocean water and carry massive clouds. When they pass near or over Mauritius or Rodrigues, they may produce heavy torrential rain. Rivers can overflow and floods may occur.

6. Rainfall distribution

- **Isohyet:** a line on a map joining places receiving the same amount of rainfall. Values are commonly shown in millimetres (mm).
- **Main controls:** rainfall varies mainly with altitude and position on the windward or leeward side.
- **Mauritius:** rainfall generally increases with height. The Central Plateau and windward east/south-east receive more rain; the lower, leeward west receives less. Curepipe is wetter than Medine because it is higher and more exposed to moist winds.
- **Rodrigues:** the higher central ridge and windward areas receive more rain than lower, leeward places. Because Rodrigues is lower than Mauritius, its relief effect is generally weaker.
- **Seasonal pattern:** Mauritius and Rodrigues generally receive more rain in summer, when convectional rain and tropical cyclones are more common, and less in winter.
- **Climate graph:** combines monthly temperature and rainfall. Use it to identify hot/cool months, wet/dry months and differences between places.

Map-reading method: Read the title and key, identify the isotherm or isohyet values, locate the station, estimate its value, then explain the pattern using altitude and windward/leeward position.

7. Climate change

- **Meaning:** long-term changes in temperature, rainfall and weather conditions around the world.
- **Observed changes:** global temperature is rising; rainfall patterns are changing; some places experience heavier rain while others face more severe drought; unusual and extreme weather occurs more often.
- **Main cause discussed in the unit:** pollution from human activities. Burning fossil fuels such as coal and oil, as well as fumes from vehicles and factories, releases carbon dioxide and warms the Earth.
- **Renewable energy:** energy from the Sun, wind and water can reduce the use of fossil fuels.
- **Actions by pupils and families:** switch off lights and appliances when not in use, save water, avoid waste and plant trees.

Essential explanations:

Temperature falls with altitude.

Rain forms when moist air rises and cools.

More relief rain falls on high windward slopes; less falls on leeward lowlands.

Climate change is linked to rising temperature, changing rainfall and more extreme weather.

GRADE 5 HISTORY & GEOGRAPHY - UNIT 5

Unit focus: How Port Louis developed from a harbour into the capital, trading port and naval base, and how Port Mathurin developed in Rodrigues.

1. Port Louis today

- **Capital city:** Port Louis is a busy city with offices, tall buildings, heavy traffic, crowded streets, shops, hawkers and vendors.
- **Cultural diversity:** mosques, churches, temples and pagodas show that people of different cultures and religions live in the city.

2. The two early harbours

- **Dutch period:** the Dutch settled at Grand Port in the south-east and called its harbour Warwyck Bay. They called the north-west harbour Noord Wester Haven but showed little interest in it.
- **French period:** after the Dutch left in 1710, France took the island and renamed it Ile de France. Governor Denis de Nyon named the north-west harbour Port Louis, although the French first continued to settle at Grand Port.

3. Why Port Louis became the main harbour

- **Problems at Grand Port:** South East Trade Winds helped ships enter but made departure difficult. Reefs and a narrow pass also made entry and exit dangerous.
- **Advantages of Port Louis:** the Port Louis-Moka mountain range sheltered the harbour from strong winds and made it safer for ships.
- **Governor Maupin:** chose Port Louis as the main harbour and had a plan drawn, but did little to develop it.

4. Labourdonnais: founder of Port Louis

- **Arrival:** Mahe de Labourdonnais became governor in 1735. Port Louis then had only a few good houses and several huts with latanier-leaf roofs.
- **Workers:** he brought engineers and planners from France; masons, carpenters, dock workers and sailors from Pondicherry and Bengal in India; and enslaved people from Madagascar and other places.
- **Buildings:** barracks for soldiers, grain stores for food, warehouses for goods, houses, a hospital, Government House, forts and roads.
- **Port facilities:** quays for loading and unloading; a shipyard to repair and build ships; and an aqueduct bringing water from Grand River North West.
- **Connections:** roads linked Port Louis with Pamplemousses and Moka.

5. Other important places

- **Champ de Mars:** used for soldiers' marching and training during the French period; it later became known for horse racing and public events.
- **Company Garden (Jardin de la Compagnie):** the area where some early French settlers and their families first lived.
- **Fort Adelaide (Citadelle):** built during the British period on high ground, giving a wide view of the harbour and city and helping protect Port Louis.

6. Port Louis as a trading centre

- **A busy port:** under Labourdonnais, more people settled in Port Louis. Ships could be repaired or built, and the port offered storage and supplies.
- **Trade route:** ships travelling between Europe, India and the East called at Port Louis to sell, exchange and store goods.
- **Goods:** cotton cloth and spices came from India; silk and porcelain from China; cereals and other food came from Madagascar, Reunion and Rodrigues. Warehouses and grain stores protected the supplies.
- **Growing importance:** the number of visiting ships increased greatly during the 18th century, making Port Louis the leading town and port of the Mascarene Islands.

7. Port Louis as a naval base

- **Defence:** the French used Port Louis as a base against the British. Fortifications, arms and cannons protected the harbour entrance.
- **Corsairs:** French corsairs left Port Louis to attack British ships during wars, increasing the port's military importance.

8. Port Louis during British rule

- **After 1810:** Port Louis remained the capital and an important trading centre after Britain captured Mauritius.
- **Commercial role:** British ships travelling between Europe and India stopped to trade. Port Louis became an important business centre and was called 'the main warehouse on the route to the East'.

9. Port Mathurin: capital of Rodrigues

- **First settlement:** Francois Leguat and his friends settled near the site in 1691. In 1722 the French sent another group to establish a settlement there.
- **Name:** Port Mathurin was named after the early French settler Mathurin Brehinier. Philibert Marragon also lived there at about the same time.
- **Slow development:** settlers lived mainly on plantations or along the coast. In the early 19th century there were only about 12 huts made of wood and latanier leaves.
- **Late 19th century:** the population reached about 280. Buildings included a magistrate's office, courtroom, prison, cook house and storehouse.
- **Today:** Port Mathurin is the capital, main harbour and administrative and commercial centre of Rodrigues.

Essential timeline and comparison

- **17th century:** the Dutch knew the north-west harbour as Noord Wester Haven but settled mainly at Grand Port.
- **18th century:** Port Louis became the main harbour of Ile de France; Labourdonnais developed the town, harbour, buildings, roads and ship facilities; it became a trading port and naval base.
- **19th century:** under British rule, Port Louis stayed the capital and became a major warehouse and commercial centre on the route to India and the East.
- **Today:** Port Louis remains the capital, main port and a centre of government, business, trade and culture.